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The Easy Yoke Is Not an Easy Exit

A follow-up reflection on faith, reason, wrestling, and the rest Christ gives

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The easy yoke is still a yoke; rest comes from the One who bears what we cannot.

In the reflection I recently shared about [a term paper I wrote twenty-five years ago](#), I wrote this sentence:

“Everyone has faith; the question is where it lies.”

One reader gave me thoughtful feedback. He appreciated my distinction between Scripture and our interpretations of Scripture, and he also appreciated the claim that [reason](#) is a gift without making reason the ultimate authority. Then he told me where I lost him: saying everyone has [faith](#) somewhere does not make the case for why Christian faith is true. I had reached the hardest and most interesting part, he said, and stopped short of wrestling with it.

That is fair feedback.

He was right. I had cleared away one objection, but I had not yet said why I believe Jesus, specifically, is worthy of [trust](#); I think I stopped there partly because that case is harder to make, and because it asks more of me than an argument about how everybody reasons.

“Everyone has faith somewhere” is not a complete case for Christianity. It clears away one misunderstanding: Christians are not the only people who begin with things they cannot prove from scratch. Every finite person relies on some combination of [testimony](#), memory, induction, authority, and first principles; that ordinary reliance is not the same thing as religious faith, much less saving faith. Reason matters enormously; none of us, however, reasons from nowhere.

That may level the field, but it does not make the Christian case. My reader was right about that.

The next question is the one I should have asked: **Who or what is worthy of our trust?**

What do I mean by faith?

The [MOOP Dictionary](#) defines faith as “confident trust grounded in the character and promises of God.” Here is the simpler way I would say it now: Christian faith is not believing without reasons; it is knowing God’s promise,

believing it is true, and personally relying on Jesus Christ—His person and finished work. It means putting the weight of your life on Him.

That faith bears fruit in willing **obedience**; the obedience, however, is the evidence of living faith, not part of the ground or instrument of our **justification**. We are justified by **grace** alone, through **faith alone**, in Christ alone. Christ alone saves. Faith contributes no merit; it is the empty hand by which we receive and **rest** upon Him.

That distinction matters. Ordinary life requires acts of trust, but ordinary trust is not saving faith. **James** reminds us that bare assent is not enough; even demons believe true things about God. Saving faith is not merely agreeing that Christian claims are interesting—or even agreeing that they are true. It is entrusting yourself to Christ.

Is the easy exit always the wrong exit?

The phrase “easy exit” stayed with me because we normally use it as an accusation. It sounds cowardly: avoiding the hard question, cutting the intellectual corner, or declaring victory before the argument is over.

Sometimes Christians do that. We can say “the Bible says it” as a substitute for learning what the Bible actually says. Jesus told people to cut off a hand or pluck out an eye if it caused them to **sin**; reading those words faithfully requires us to recognize deliberate hyperbole, not to treat interpretation as unbelief. The Bible settles the matter because God speaks truly; that does not release us from the duty to understand what He said.

At the same time, I have had to admit that I can confuse a harder answer with a more honest one. Sometimes it is; sometimes it is only harder.

I know the temptation to treat uncertainty as proof that I am taking a question seriously; uncertainty can be honest, however, without becoming the place I am required to live forever. Some people wrestle through grief, betrayal, trauma, or genuinely difficult intellectual barriers; Christ meets them with truth and gentleness, not contempt.

Scripture gives us many forms of struggle: **Jacob** physically clings to God in **Genesis 32**, Job laments and protests amid suffering, and Thomas resists the testimony of the other disciples in **John 20**. These are not identical experiences, but none is presented as an end in itself. God meets His people in their struggle and summons them toward trust, worship, and faithful obedience.

Rest is not the enemy of serious thought; pretending our questions are settled when they are not—that is the real danger.

Rest is not evasion

*“Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me ... For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.” — **Matthew 11:28–30***

Notice both halves of the invitation. Christ says, “Come to me,” and He also says, “learn from me.” His **yoke** is not effortless or free from costly obedience. It is good and gracious because the **Teacher** is gentle and lowly, because He bears what we cannot bear, and because submission to Him restores rather than destroys us.

There is a difference between a cheap answer and a gracious answer; there is also a difference between dodging a question and finally finding somewhere solid enough to rest.

Evasion says, “I do not want to look.” Christian rest says, “I have looked, I am still learning, and I have found Jesus trustworthy.”

Hebrews captures the paradox by telling us to “be diligent to enter that rest.” We enter God’s rest by faith, yet that faith **perseveres** rather than hardening into the **unbelief** and disobedience exemplified by Israel. Grace ends every attempt at self-justification; it does not produce passivity, but persevering trust as we await the fullness of God’s promised rest.

Peter likewise tells Christians who already possess **hope** to be ready to give a reason for it (**1 Peter 3**). **Peace** and reasoned defense are not enemies. A settled hope should make patient explanation more possible, not less. Christianity gives us room to ask hard questions without making the questions themselves our savior.

Why Christian faith is not arbitrary

If everyone trusts something, it does not follow that every object of trust is equally sound. Sincerity cannot make an unreliable object reliable. Faith in faith saves no one. Peace by itself proves nothing; a person may feel peaceful and still be profoundly wrong.

Christianity offers a coherent account of features of reality that rival visions must also explain. The world is intelligible because it is the work of a wise Creator. Human beings possess profound dignity because they bear God's **image**, yet they are capable of terrible evil because sin has corrupted—not erased—that image. Our persistent sense of moral obligation and guilt fits a world in which we are accountable to a holy God, while the **gospel** explains why our deepest need is not merely improvement but **reconciliation** and grace. That does not prove every Christian claim by itself; it is part of why I keep listening when Christianity tells me who Jesus is.



The empty tomb is not a mood; it is the public claim on which the faith stands or falls.

At the center stands Jesus Christ—His public ministry and **crucifixion**, the **empty tomb**, the testimony of those who said they saw Him risen, and the apostolic proclamation that followed. Paul did not merely tell the Athenians that everyone worships something and walk away (**Acts 17**); he exposed their commitments, proclaimed the Creator, announced judgment, and pointed to the **resurrection**. John says that Jesus' signs were recorded so readers may believe.

The Christian claim is not “believe whatever gives you peace.” It is that God acted in Christ in history, and that this action was publicly proclaimed from the beginning by **witnesses** who staked their lives upon its truth. Paul's summary in **1 Corinthians 15** preserves resurrection testimony he had received and passed on. Historical inquiry can examine that testimony, its early proclamation, and the rise of the Christian movement; it cannot put a unique ancient event into a laboratory and repeat it.

So I will not call the resurrection “historically verified.” That claims too much. I will call it what it is: **a public historical claim, supported by testimony that can be examined and contested, on which Christianity stands or falls.**

I realize that naming the resurrection is not the same as making the full historical case for it; that deserves its own honest treatment. What I can say here is that my faith does not rest on a vague spiritual feeling. It stands or falls with the claim that Jesus truly died and truly rose.

Reason can examine testimony, expose contradictions, and test whether our claims cohere with reality; Christ alone, however, saves. A person does not have to answer every objection before taking an honest step toward Him. I certainly did not.

Augustine wrote that our hearts are restless until they rest in God. That rest is not intellectual laziness; it is the creature reaching his proper end.

Free to wrestle—and free from endless wrestling

I am grateful for the feedback because it showed me exactly where the first essay needed another step. “Everyone has faith somewhere” is the beginning of the argument, not its conclusion. The real question is which object of trust can bear the weight we place upon it.

Christianity answers: Jesus Christ.

We are free to wrestle because Christianity does not fear our questions. Christ does not save us because our questions are unusually sophisticated, nor does He reject us merely because some questions remain unresolved.

Some questions choose us, and some seasons of **doubt** are painful in ways outsiders cannot see. We should not rush people through them; neither should we tell them that peace would make their faith less honest. We should examine our beliefs, answer objections honestly, and repent when our interpretations are careless. We do not have to remain **anxious** in order to prove that our questions were sincere.

The easy yoke is not an easy exit. It is not permission to stop thinking; it is freedom from trying to establish truth by our own strength, justify ourselves by our own works, or secure **salvation** by our own striving.

I do not think certainty is a prize God gives to the person who has struggled the longest. The better question is whether Jesus can be trusted.

Christian faith does not ask us to believe in belief. It asks us to entrust ourselves to Jesus Christ—the One whose character, cross, and **bodily resurrection** make Him worthy of that trust. We may wrestle honestly on the way to Him, and we may continue asking hard questions after coming to Him. Christ does not shame the weary or require endless uncertainty as proof of sincerity. He says, “Come to Me ... and I will give you rest.”

His easy yoke is not an escape from truth. It is the freedom of resting in the One who is true, even as we rise to follow Him.

Same battlefield, one question further.

Editorial note: This follow-up was revised after consultation for theological precision, logical clarity, and pastoral warmth. The reader’s feedback is quoted anonymously and with identifying details omitted. Linked definitions are from the **MOOP Dictionary**; Scripture links open the **Bible Translation Engine** chapter or verse pages.